



— FREE READINESS CHECKLIST

PBIS Referral System Readiness Checklist

A quick audit for school leaders who want behavior referrals to lead to better follow-up, cleaner data, and stronger PBIS team decisions.

Use it to evaluate your current referral process and identify exactly where your system is working — and where it needs support.

4 sections · 40-point audit

Built by a practicing principal

Created by Workaround Amy

Principal-created systems for real school workflows

workaroundamy.com

— START HERE

Behavior referrals should do more than document an incident.

At their best, referrals create a clear record that helps staff feel supported, admin respond consistently, and your PBIS team use real data to make real decisions.

But in many schools the process has grown into something that collects a lot of information without always leading to clear follow-up or meaningful team action. Referrals come in through different channels. Admin responses live in email threads or memory. And the data that lands in a spreadsheet rarely makes it back to the PBIS team in a usable format.

This checklist helps you take an honest look at where your referral system is right now — what's working, what's inconsistent, and where the gaps are. **You don't need a perfect system to start. You just need a clear picture of what you have.**

QUICK REFLECTION

Before you begin, answer these five honestly. There are no right or wrong answers — they're here to warm up your thinking.

- 1 Do staff know when to submit a behavior referral?
- 2 Do staff know the difference between documentation-only and "admin support needed"?
- 3 Does admin have a clear, consistent way to respond back to staff?
- 4 Can your PBIS team easily see behavior patterns across your building?
- 5 Does your referral data help you make decisions — or does it mostly sit in a spreadsheet?

TIP

If you hesitated on more than two of these questions, your referral system likely has some gaps this checklist will help you identify — and that's exactly what it's for. ~>

1 SECTION 1 Staff Referral Clarity

Check each item that accurately describes your current referral system.

- ☐ Staff understand when a behavior incident warrants a formal referral versus classroom documentation only.
- ☐ Staff know when to request admin support versus managing the behavior themselves first.
- ☐ Staff use consistent, agreed-upon behavior categories when submitting referrals.
- ☐ Staff write objective, factual descriptions rather than interpretive or emotional language.
- ☐ Staff avoid unnecessarily naming or identifying other students in referral descriptions.
- ☐ Staff identify the location where the behavior occurred.
- ☐ Staff identify the approximate time or time window of the behavior.
- ☐ Staff identify a possible function or motivation for the behavior when known.
- ☐ Staff know what happens after they submit a referral and what follow-up to expect.
- ☐ There is a shared understanding among staff about what a complete, useful referral looks like.

WHY IT MATTERS

When staff don't have a shared definition of what belongs in a referral, your data becomes inconsistent before it even reaches admin. Clarity at submission is the foundation of everything else.

2 SECTION 2 Admin Follow-Up

Check each item that accurately describes your current referral system.

- ☐ Admin receives all referrals in one consistent, predictable location.
- ☐ Admin can quickly identify which referrals require immediate follow-up versus documentation only.
- ☐ Admin has a clear way to respond back to the staff member who submitted the referral.
- ☐ Admin can track whether a referral loop is open, closed, or being actively monitored.
- ☐ Admin can determine whether a referral requires entry into the SIS or student data system.
- ☐ Admin response notes are stored with — or directly linked to — the original referral.
- ☐ Admin follow-up does not rely primarily on memory or standalone email threads.
- ☐ Referrals are reviewed within a consistent timeframe rather than when time allows.
- ☐ Admin can identify patterns in their own follow-up — response time, actions taken, outcomes.
- ☐ There is a clear process for escalating a referral if follow-up reveals a higher level of need.

3 SECTION 3 Data Quality

Check each item that accurately describes your current referral system.

- ☐ Referral data consistently includes behavior type or category.
- ☐ Referral data consistently includes location.
- ☐ Referral data consistently includes time of day or time window.
- ☐ Referral data consistently includes grade level or homeroom.
- ☐ Referral data includes a field for possible function or motivation of behavior.
- ☐ Referral data includes admin action taken or response provided.
- ☐ Referral data can be sorted, filtered, or reviewed without significant manual cleanup.
- ☐ Duplicate or inconsistent entries are uncommon and easy to identify when they occur.
- ☐ Data fields are used consistently, so that behavior categories mean the same thing across staff.
- ☐ Your referral data, as it currently exists, could be brought to a PBIS team meeting and used.

WHY IT MATTERS

Data quality determines whether your team can use referrals as a decision tool. Missing fields and inconsistent categories make patterns invisible — even when the information exists somewhere.

4 SECTION 4 PBIS Team Use

Check each item that accurately describes your current referral system.

- ☐ The PBIS team reviews behavior referral data on a regular, scheduled basis.
- ☐ The team can identify the most frequent behavior types in your building.
- ☐ The team can identify the locations where the most behaviors are occurring.
- ☐ The team can identify the times of day that need the most attention or support.
- ☐ The team can identify individual students who may need Tier 2 or Tier 3 review.
- ☐ The team can determine whether a Tier 1 reteaching or supervision adjustment is needed.
- ☐ The team uses referral data to decide on specific, actionable next steps.
- ☐ Data review meetings produce action items — not just discussion and observation.
- ☐ PBIS team decisions are connected back to the original referral data and documented.
- ☐ Your team can tell the difference between a student pattern and a setting/system pattern.

— ADD IT UP

Score yourself

Count the total number of items you checked across all four sections. Then find your score range below.

ITEMS

0–10

Foundation stage

Your referral system may be collecting information, but it may not yet be supporting clear follow-up or PBIS decision-making. This is a common starting point — and this checklist gives you a clear picture of where to begin.

ITEMS

11–25

Pieces in place

You have some helpful pieces in place. Your system may still rely too much on manual follow-up, individual memory, or inconsistent entry. Strengthening a few key areas could make a meaningful difference for staff and students.

ITEMS

26–35

On the right track

Your system is on the right track. You've built a solid foundation, and a more connected, streamlined workflow could help make your process easier to sustain and more useful for your PBIS team.

ITEMS

36+

Strong system

You have a strong referral system in place. You may be ready for a more advanced data-review setup — one that connects your referral workflow directly to a PBIS dashboard for snapshot data, pattern review, and team action items.

What your results mean

No matter where you landed, this checklist isn't meant to grade your school — it's meant to give you useful information. Every building is somewhere on this journey, and every principal who takes the time to look honestly at their system is already doing something important.

Find your range

A closer look at what your score suggests about your next move.

If you scored 0–10

You're likely dealing with inconsistency at the foundation — in how staff submit referrals, how admin responds, and how data gets captured. The good news is that this is completely fixable with the right structure in place. Start with staff clarity and a consistent submission process, and build from there.

If you scored 11–25

You have a referral process, but it may be inconsistent or dependent on the right people doing the right things at the right time. This range is very common in schools that are actively working on PBIS but haven't yet connected the referral workflow to a reliable follow-up and data-review system.

If you scored 26–35

You're doing a lot of things well. The gaps here are often about sustainability and efficiency — making sure the system works even on hard weeks, not just when everyone has extra time. A more structured or connected workflow can help you close those remaining gaps without adding more work.

If you scored 36+

Your referral system is functioning at a high level. You may be ready to shift from "making it work" to "making it easy" — with a dashboard, automated follow-up tools, and a structured PBIS data-review cycle that's built right into your existing workflow.

— WHEN YOU'RE READY

Ready for a next step?

If your checklist showed that your school needs a clearer, more consistent referral workflow, the resources below were built for exactly that. Both are principal-created systems designed for real school workflows — no IT support required, no steep learning curve, and no duct tape holding things together.

BUILD THE FOUNDATION

PBIS Discipline Referral Starter Kit

If your checklist showed that your school needs a clearer referral workflow, this gives you a ready-to-use Google Form + Google Sheet system. It's the foundation your referral process needs — already built.

- ✓ Behavior documentation + admin follow-up
- ✓ Submission links + email notifications
- ✓ Homeroom mapping + system checks
- ✓ Test-data cleanup

[View on workaroundamy.com →](#)

ADD THE DATA REVIEW

PBIS Behavior Referral + Dashboard System

If your school is ready for a full PBIS data-review workflow, this includes the complete referral workflow plus a PBIS dashboard — everything your team needs to move from data collection to data-driven decisions.

- ✓ Snapshot data + behavior graphs
- ✓ TFI evidence + action items
- ✓ Support flags + staff calibration flags
- ✓ Recent referral log

[View on workaroundamy.com →](#)

Both resources are available at [workaroundamy.com](#).

[Take a look →](#)



ONE LAST THING

Ready to make your referral system easier to use?

Your referral system should do more than collect incidents. It should help your team respond, document, review patterns, and make better decisions for students.

Come build with me.

Workaround Amy